

September 2, 2026

## Taproot Plus + Leatherwood MATTERS

1-Hour Project-Scoping Session

Richland Historical Database / Digital History System

|                                                                                                |                                                                                         |                                                                                                     |
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| <b>Ms. Bea Sanders</b><br>Executive Director<br>Leatherwood MATTERS<br>beasanders847@gmail.com | <b>Ms. Donna Sanders</b><br>Supervisor<br>Leatherwood MATTERS<br>donna@iamartlegacy.org | <b>Mr. Arie Meir</b><br>Taproot Volunteer<br>xGoogle Senior Product Manager<br>arie.coach@gmail.com |
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### Purpose of the Session

Use a one-hour consultation with an experienced technology/data professional to help Leatherwood MATTERS **define and scope the problem** before launching a larger database architecture project.

### Project Links

[Intro Video](#)- Our Vision for Final Project

[Technical Brief](#) – Key Challenges

### 1. Short Project Background

- [Historic Richland Cemetery](#) is a historic African American cemetery in Greenville, South Carolina.
- Burial and historical information exists across different records and systems.
- Leatherwood Matters is preparing an [AmeriCorps VISTA](#) project to build sustainable research and data infrastructure.
- A Data Systems & Research VISTA will ultimately implement and document the system.
- The City of Greenville already maintains [cemetery/GIS information](#).
- Leatherwood wants to connect the City's information with much richer historical research.

### 2. The Problem - WHO + WHERE + EVIDENCE

#### WHO

- Person buried at Richland
- Family relationships
- Military service
- Occupations

- Residences
- Churches and organizations
- Businesses
- Education
- Life story

## WHERE

- City cemetery record
- Grave
- Section
- Plot
- GPS coordinates
- Headstone
- GIS map

## EVIDENCE

- Death certificates
- Birth/marriage records
- Census
- Military records
- Newspapers
- Photographs
- Obituaries
- Oral histories
- Audio/video
- Other historical sources

*Core question: How should WHO, WHERE and EVIDENCE ultimately work together as one sustainable historical information system?*

### 3. One Real Example - Sam Smith

- Sam Smith has a grave at Richland.
- City GIS identifies the grave/location.
- Sam receives a permanent Person ID.
- Researchers locate census, military, newspaper and other records.
- Acrobat makes documents searchable through OCR.
- Evidence files are stored on Synology.
- Verified facts and relationships are entered into the historical database.
- The person record connects back to the grave/GIS.
- A permanent QR code ultimately leads visitors to Sam Smith's public record.

*What would need to be defined before a technology professional could design a system capable of doing this reliably for hundreds or thousands of people?*

#### **4. Current Technology Environment**

- City of Greenville GIS - cemetery/location data
- Synology NAS - evidence/document repository
- Adobe Acrobat Pro - OCR and historical document processing
- Salesforce - organizational CRM, separate from the historical database
- GISCorps - potential professional GIS assistance
- Taproot - professional technology expertise
- AmeriCorps VISTA - implementation, documentation and capacity building
- Historical database platform - TBD; professional advice is wanted before selecting it.

#### **5. What We Think the Larger Project Might Include**

- Requirements Assessment
- Platform Recommendation
- Database Architecture / Schema
- Integration Architecture
- VISTA Implementation Roadmap

*Are these the right deliverables, or are we missing something or combining things that should be separate projects?*

#### **6. Constraints the Consultant Should Know**

- Small nonprofit with a limited technology budget.
- Preference for \$0 or low-cost solutions.
- System must be sustainable after VISTA service ends.
- Cannot require a full-time database administrator.
- Must be understandable and documented for future staff and volunteers.
- Must accommodate growth over time.
- Must work with City GIS rather than duplicate it.
- Evidence must remain traceable to historical claims.
- Public access is ultimately important.
- Long-term institutional ownership and stewardship matter.

#### **7. Questions We Want Answered During the Hour**

- Are we defining the problem correctly?
- Is WHO + WHERE + EVIDENCE a sound way to frame it?
- What information should we obtain from the City?

- What sample data should we prepare?
- What historical fields should be defined beforehand?
- What should we document about Synology/evidence storage?
- What user roles and permissions should we define?
- What integration requirements need to be known?
- What should we decide about public access and QR codes now versus later?
- Are we trying to accomplish too much in one project?
- What type of professional should we recruit for the multi-week project?
- What should that professional actually deliver?
- What should Leatherwood have ready on Day 1 of that project?

## 8. What We Do NOT Need Yet

- Final database platform
- Final database schema
- Every historical field finalized
- Thousands of records cleaned
- Complete City GIS integration specifications
- Final QR system
- Final public website
- Complete data migration
- Detailed technical architecture
- Database built

## What Success Looks Like After 60 Minutes

- PROBLEM - a clearer definition of what we are actually solving.
- SCOPE - what belongs in the database architecture project and what does not.
- PREPARATION CHECKLIST - exactly what Leatherwood needs to assemble.
- EXPERT PROFILE - what skills to look for in the 1-2 Taproot volunteers.
- PROJECT SCOPE - what the eventual multi-week Taproot project should deliver.

# Leatherwood Matters

## Relational Historical Database



### FAMILY



Parents:  
Henry Williams  
Mary E. Williams  
Siblings:  
James Williams  
Sarah Williams  
Emma Williams  
Spouse:  
Nannie Williams  
Children:  
John, Jr.  
Robert  
Evelyn



### RESIDENCE



123 Pendleton Street  
Greenville, SC  
Zip: 29601  
Ward 4



### OCCUPATION

U.S. Census, 1910

|            |                  |
|------------|------------------|
| Name       | John H. Williams |
| Age        | 14               |
| Occupation | Bootblack        |
| Industry   | Service          |
| Employer   | Self             |
| Literacy   | Read / Write     |
| Birthplace | S.C.             |



### BIOGRAPHY / STORY

John H. Williams was born in Greenville, SC to Henry and Mary E. Williams. He worked as a bootblack in downtown Greenville. He enlisted in 1917 and trained at Camp Sevier with the 365th Infantry. He died of pneumonia during the 1918 epidemic. He is buried at Richland Cemetery. He left behind a wife, Nannie, and three young children.



**PVT. JOHN H. WILLIAMS**  
1896 – 1918

Richland Cemetery, Greenville, SC



### MILITARY SERVICE

REGISTRATION CARD  
Name John H. Williams 21  
Date of Birth Aug. 12, 1896  
Race Negro  
Employer's Name City of Greenville  
Nearest Relative Mrs. Nannie Williams  
123 Pendleton St.  
Greenville, S.C.  
Ind. John H. Williams

COMPANY D, 365TH INFANTRY  
U.S. SERVICE RECORD  
Enlisted: Sept. 5, 1917  
Camp: Camp Sevier, S.C.  
Trained at: Camp Sevier  
Deployed: Overseas  
Rank: Private  
Honorable Discharge: June 15, 1919

CAMP SEVIER, S.C.  
Training African American  
Soldiers for World War I



### COMMUNITY



Mt. Bethel AME Church  
Member  
Sunday School  
Usher Board  
Choir



### HISTORICAL RECORDS

The Greenville News  
October 12, 1918

Local Soldier  
Dies of Pneumonia  
at Camp Sevier

Pvt. John H. Williams,  
Co. D, 365th Infantry,  
died October 10, 1918,  
at Camp Sevier, S.C.  
of pneumonia.

STATE OF SOUTH CAROLINA  
CERTIFICATE OF DEATH

Name John H. Williams  
Date of Death October 10, 1918  
Place of Death Camp Sevier, S.C.  
Cause of Death Pneumonia  
J. F. Eyles, M.D.  
Registrar

STANDARD CERTIFICATE  
OF MARRIAGE

John H. Williams  
and  
Nannie E. Brown  
March 12, 1916  
Greenville, S.C.  
J. M. Sims  
Registrar



365th Infantry  
Camp Sevier, S.C.



PEOPLE



RELATIONSHIPS



RECORDS



STORIES

50 "WHO" FIELDS

People • Relationships • Records • Stories

# Richland Insta Tours

*One Cemetery. Many Stories.*

One City GIS Map • Many Thematic Tours • Countless Stories to Discover

## Veterans of Richland



Honoring the men and women who served our country.

## Families of Richland



The families who built our community and our legacy.

## Camp Sevier & Our WWI Story



The "Lost Battalion" of Camp Sevier and Richland's connection to World War I.



## Women of Richland



The strength, faith and leadership of Richland's women.

## Teachers & Education



Educators who shaped minds and changed lives.

## Richland Tour Examples

- ✓ Veterans Walking Tour
- ✓ Women of Richland Tour
- ✓ Families of Richland Tour
- ✓ Teachers & Education Tour
- ✓ Camp Sevier & WWI Tour

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👥 *Honoring the Past.  
Inspiring the Future.*